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Kuki Shūzō and the Question of Origins

The idea of metaphysics as a reflection of one's own view of life and the world is key to Kuki's philosophy. At the heart of his metaphysics is a theory of primal contingency as the origin of all things, which he developed roughly between 1932 and 1935. Primal contingency is comprised of two aspects, one of which refers to the natural world, or *physis*; and the other to the world of mind and spirit, or *psyche*. This distinction was elaborated after he formulated a general theory of the eternal return of time. This led him to abandon his previous view of the creation of the world by subjective will and redefined the creativity of the subject as a collaboration between the microcosm of the individual life and the macrocosm of the whole of reality. This shift was occasioned by his study of the aesthetic theory of the German philosopher Oscar Becker, from whom he picked up the notions of "carriedness" and "fragility" and applied them to his theory of primal contingency. This paper will trace this shift in Kuki's thinking.

KEYWORDS: Kuki Shūzō—Oskar Becker—origins—primal contingency—eternal return—para-existence—macrocosm—microcosm—carriedness—fragility

In 1934, at the request of the journal *Risō* (『理想』), Kuki Shūzō 九鬼周造 (1888–1941) submitted a paper which the publishers entitled "My View of Human Life" (「我が人生観」). The essay was republished in 1939 as "A View of Human Life" and included in a collection of his essays, *Human Beings and Existence*. In it he sets philosophical anthropology and the philosophy of existence squarely at the center of his metaphysics, arguing that one's view of human life and one's view of the world are bound at the roots. Accordingly, Kuki argues that his own view of human life must be taken into full account when treating traditional metaphysical questions such as the soul, free will, and God.[1] The same holds true for the two concepts he considered the core of his own metaphysics: primal contingency (原始偶然) and eternal return (永遠回帰)—the rubrics under which he takes up the notions of free will and the immortality of the soul.[2]

Kuki's identification of views of human life and views of the world does not imply anything like a universal metaphysics. It simply affirms that metaphysics, which belongs to the realm of the ideal, requires an understanding of the human existential condition as it is in actuality. In addition to obvious affinities with Kant and the phenomenologists, Kuki considered himself an existentialist. Unlike the leading thinkers of the Kyoto School, whose influence on him was considerable, he was not prepared to assert the concrete reality of the metaphysical as such. For him, metaphysics is always a construct of mind from a particular perspective.

To illustrate Kuki's way of approaching metaphysics, I propose to take up the question of the origins of reality, which arose in his discussions of primal contingency and eternal return. Given the strong influence of Christian

1.「人生観」『人間と実存』[Human beings and Existenz], in KSZ 3: 95.

2. KSZ 3: 97–9.

doctrine on Western philosophy, it is hardly surprising to find philosophers all the way up to Kant assuming that the world was the creation of God. Kuki himself had been baptized a Christian in 1911, but by the time he had published his first essay in 1928, he had left his faith behind. Accordingly, the question of the ultimate origins of reality would have to be taken up within a philosophical perspective in which divinity does not play a role. The way forward was far from smooth. For the next decade and more, he attempted a variety of complex responses to the problem of origins, which not only reflected overt changes in his thinking, but alert us to subtler, latent shifts in his overall philosophical position.

The productive power of primal contingency

Perhaps the clearest introduction to Kuki's concept of primal contingency is provided in his principal work on the subject published in 1935, *The Problem of Contingency*, and a short but informative essay in 1939 entitled "Surprise and Contingency." From them we pick up the following terse definitions:

> We pursue an ideal *x* "endlessly" on the assumption that when it comes to the realm of experience, we are under the complete control of necessity. However, when we take hold of that ideal in the realm of the "infinite" beyond experience, we must speak of a "primal contingency."[3]
>
> The reason we consider primal contingency contingent must be sought in the *presentness* that exists contingently at this given moment as a "now." Nothing we pursue in the *pastness* is contingent; nothing we expect in *futurity* is contingent. Only in *presentness* can we speak of contingency.[4]
>
> Primal contingency is a limit mode (*Grenzmodus*). The actual given world has to be seen as an unfolding of this primal contingency.
>
> We are astounded when we finally run into primal contingency. In the end, there is no way to erase the surprise.[5]

3.『偶然性の問題』[The problem of contingency] in KSZ 2: 146.

4. KSZ 2: 210.

5.「驚きの情と偶然性」[Surprise and contingency] in KSZ 3: 174. The idea of contingency as a *Grenzmodus* comes from Nicholai Hartmann 1966: 87–8.

> Philosophy indeed begins in wonder. It not only begins there, it ends there as well. Philosophy begins in surprise and ends in surprise.[6]

Primal contingency, then, is an idea that one discovers at the limits of reason. Kuki came to it by considering the present as one event in a causal series of events. More than a mere restatement of the abstract principle of causality, the notion of primal contingency is rooted in the world as it is and the surprise we feel at realizing we have been thrown into it at this time and place. This is where metaphysics comes in. The laws of empirical science only take us so far in understanding a chain of events rationally as a causal series. But our actual, lived experience of causality as primal contingency oversteps the limits of reason. It literally conducts us from physics to metaphysics.

For Kuki, the origins of the world—the start of the chain of events that makes up reality—can be traced back to a primal contingency that does not belong to a causal chain reaching back into a distant past but is fully recapitulated in the "now" of *presentness*. This means that the present in which we find ourselves contains the very origins of the world within it, and in this sense, that the world is regenerated in each instant. Contingency itself is not something the rational subject can understand. Kuki's definitions of primal contingency are not attempts at rational explanation. Nevertheless, the experience of surprise can lead one to ask for reasons, and that is where philosophy begins.

If the world is regenerated and begins anew at each instant, how do series of events take shape? To answer this question, Kuki introduced the element of "production" (生産) into his description of primal contingency and its emergence in interpersonal encounter. Although Kuki speaks here simply of "contingency," the context makes it clear that he is discussing primal contingency:

> Contingency connects the fragile peaks of existence at the point of their actual reality and does so with the passion of a productive principle that carries through all productive activity in reality.... Contingency itself signals a bare minimum of impossibility and each possibility embraces other possibilities within it. By taking hold of the most minimal possibility at any of those

6. KSZ 3: 176.

> endangered peaks of existence, contingency is able to give an "I" to a "thou" and a "thou" to an "I" so that it finally comes to coincide with necessity.[7]
>
> Retrospectively, we are able to ground the wonder of contingency on the future. Contingency is the point at which impossibility and possibility come into contact. We can understand the productive meaning of present contingency retrospectively by tracing the path of a minimal possibility contained in it and following it through the performative curve along which its possibilities were fostered and unfolded into the future. It introduces wonder into the moment of encounter by providing the production of the future with a "purposeless purpose."[8]

The allusion to performance directs our attention to an important aspect of his theory. The subject of performance and its power to perform are contingent because of the very fact that they exist. But *contingency* as such can only arise with the reflective judgment of a subject who has been engaged in actual productive action. The retrospect from the future into the past which gives meaning to the process of productive action and elicits our surprise, leads us to ask about the role of purpose in productive action. For Kuki, purpose is not merely a matter of the agency of will but has to include the contingent nature of existence, whose purpose is not to have a purpose. What he gives us in effect is a kind of inverted teleology: the subject finds its purpose for action only after having completed the action. No matter how great the passion with which one performs, the results are often unexpected, and this leads to rethinking in hindsight the original purpose behind that passion. In a word, primal contingency possesses the productive power to give meaning and reason to events, to form events that take place in the world into series. Kuki's inverted teleology is intended to explain how it exercises that power by connecting discrete moments of presentedness. Despite the fragile and indeterminate nature of contingent beings, reflection on primal contingency produces meaning latent in the present but only visible in hindsight. This meaning is what transforms nonrational contingency into rational necessity.

To sum up, we might say that Kuki's notion of primal contingency can be

7. KSZ 2: 187–8.

8. KSZ 2: 259.

seen both as *physis* and as *psyche*.[9] As *physis*, it is an *actual fact* that accounts for the origins of the world into which we are thrown. It is transcendent insofar as it lies beyond the reach of reason. Even if we cannot explain it, we have no choice but to accept it. As *psyche*, it is a *productive power* whose ability to fill the actual world with meaning is grasped in the impassioned performance of human subjects. The inverted teleology this entails is the basis of the romanticized idea of a subject that creates its own destiny. In this sense, primal contingency is both the absolute other and the passionate subject.

These two aspects of primal contingency come together in the notion of *poiesis*, to which we will return in our discussion of eternal return.

The creative power of the will

On the face of it, the two aspects of primal contingency just considered would appear to be incompatible. A closer look at Kuki's approach to metaphysics prior to his introduction of the notion of primal contingency may help clear up the confusion. In his first published paper, "La Notion du temps et la reprise sur le temps en Orient," which appeared in 1928 when he was already forty years old, Kuki presented the idea of eternal return as an example of fatalism in Eastern philosophy:

> More precisely, we see it in the transition from one Great Year to another, or in the chain of Great Years. "Like a man swaying on a rope suspended from a tree above a ditch," a Great Year swings towards another Great Year. Is he an idiot passively strung up by time? Is he a child who needs a "supervisor"? Isn't he rather like a clever magician who creates his own new time anew? First of all, we have established that time belongs to the will and that there is no time without will. Thus, this magician, all on his own, is a veritable demon possessed of the strength or will power to end one existence and be reborn into another. No doubt, between his death and rebirth, his will does not *actually* exist, yet it does exist *potentially*.[10]

9. I am drawing on the terminology of Oskar Becker, to which I will return later. He considered the macrocosm of nature a kind of mystical "para-existence," and the microcosm of the mind, as something spiritual (Becker 1963, 35–6).

10. KSZ 1: 289.

Kuki uses the Great Year, or cyclical return of the alignment of the cosmos, as a metaphor for the beginning and end of the universe.[11] Curiously, he imagines the cosmos as a man swinging on a rope who effects a new cycle of time by simply willing it. Having dismissed the idea of a divine "supervisor," Kuki attributes the creation of the world to human will, like a magician working absolute isolation. Time and space are one and the same here, as are the world and the willing subject. Everything begins and ends with the will of this solitary man on a swing, but he is indistinguishable from the world in both its materiality and its temporality. There is no escaping the charge of solipsism in this way of thinking, and that sets up a conflict between primal contingency, where purpose and will are first discovered in retrospect, and the "clever magician," who is pure will and a purpose unto himself. From the standpoint of primal contingency, the subject with all its passions is ultimately passive before the world. The magical creativity of the will is the very opposite: it creates actively. Despite these differences, and the fact that contingency does not figure prominently in his argument, this essay assembles the basic elements that would later go into his discussion of primal contingency as *psyche*.

The image of the will as creative magician does not appear in later works where Kuki takes up the idea of eternal return. In any case, it would be naïve to assume that he understood the image literally. Part of his motivation for speaking in those terms was to advance the exposure of Eastern philosophy in France. In 1928, the idea of adopting and modifying sources from Buddhism and the Upanishads to make a philosophical argument that was otherwise framed in existential and phenomenological language, was highly original.

Kuki's essay has earned critical acclaim from leading Japanese philosophers, among them, Sakabe Megumi, Obama Yoshinobu, Itō Kunitake, and Furukawa Yūji.[12] In addition to the novelty of its approach as a bridge between philosophies East and West, its analysis of the reversibility of time

11. "Great Year" refers to a cycle of cosmic alignment in the orientation of Earth's axis that modern astronomy calculates to return roughly every 25,800 years. Kuki is using the term in a more classical sense, citing its appearance in Pythagoras and the Stoics. In his Japanese translation of the essay cited here, Kuki translates it as 宇宙年 or "cosmic year" (KSZ 5: 18).

12. See Sakabe 1990, Obama 2006, Itō 2014, and Furukawa 2015.

is of particular interest. The essay is widely considered to blend seamlessly into Kuki's general philosophical thought, but a closer examination of his notion of eternal return shows that the conflict between the ideas of primal contingency and the solitary power of will needed to be resolved in favor of one or the other.

Microcosms afloat in the macrocosm

Three years after his essay on the creative will, Kuki took up the question of eternal return once more in an essay entitled "Metaphysical Time," which proved to be pivotal for the structure of his principal work *The Problem of Contingency*. Near the end of the piece, Kuki reflects:

> I have already presented the main gist of this paper in *Propos sur le Temps* (1928, Paris). After its publication, Becker referred to a related problem in a paper for the *Jahrbuch für Philosophie und Phänomenologische Forschung* (Husserl-Festschrift, 1929). I was therefore able to reference the similarity of his thinking to the ideas expressed here.[13]

Commentators on Kuki's idea of eternal return have tended to pass over this essay and concentrate on a careful reading of "La Notion du temps et la reprise sur le temps en Orient." His own words seem to all but justify the negligence. His discussion of Oskar Becker (1889–1964) in connection with the discord between primal contingency and the creative power of the will tells a different story.

To begin with, in his earlier essay he points out that Eastern philosophy shares the tendency of modern Western philosophers to view time as a function of consciousness and will. But unlike the linear image of time prevalent in the West, the great intellectual traditions of the East have imagined time as a circle without beginning or end. What is not clear in his 1928 essay is which of the two he wished to affirm. Already from the beginning he speaks of time as a circle eternally returning on itself,[14] but his metaphor of the "clever magician" assumes—or least strongly suggests—a linear view of time. In "Metaphysical Time," he clears up the confusion: Time is not an

13.「形而上学的時間」KSZ 3: 197.

14. KSZ 1: 294–5 (54–5); 400–1.

arrow that travels in one direction or a line that extends from the past into the future, but an ever-repeating circular movement.[15]

Now if metaphysics is the pursuit of the "absolute ground" of things, Kuki asks, where do we find the ground of time? To answer this, he begins by asking whether time is ultimately finite or infinite. Given the difficulty of imagining time as having a beginning or end at any specific point, the idea of time as finite is self-contradictory. If we imagine time as a straight line extending infinitely in both directions, we can only ever grasp time in sections, never as a whole. The only kind of infinite line without a beginning or end is a line that turns back on itself to form a circle: the absolute ground of time is to be sought in the idea of an eternal return.[16]

In "Metaphysical Time," Kuki does more than simply affirm a cyclical notion of time. Where previously he had reduced time to the consciousness and will of the individual subject, he now sees it as independent of human beings. What is more, the style of argument that accompanies the shift is more rigorously deductive. For Kuki, the universe is no longer a creation of the will; it no longer has a beginning; there is no such thing as a transition from one cosmic aeon to another. The eternal return of time is clearly detached from the workings of the conscious mind.

This is not to say that the question of origins has been set aside altogether. On the one hand, because his focus was on time as a whole, he did not have to consider time as a transition from one event to another and trace them back to a beginning point. On the other, precisely because he had disassociated the world from the creative activity of human will, the problem of the origins of the world was bound to return in clearer relief. Primal contingency would be the answer to that problem, but it would have to await his more general discussion of contingency. At the same time, we find intimations of that idea in his treatment of Oskar Becker's notion of *Getragenheit* or "carriednness."

Becker, one of Husserl's leading disciples, had taught Kuki philosophy at Freiburg, where he served Husserl as a research assistant upon completion of his habilitation. In 1931 he moved to Bonn where he spent the rest of his academic career until his death in 1964. His writings range from the phenom-

15. KSZ 3: 179, 190.

16. KSZ 3: 177–80.

enology and history of mathematics to modal logic and aesthetics. Though he is not particularly well known today, Kuki regarded him as a major figure in the phenomenological movement, rivaling Husserl and Heidegger. Kuki's frequent references to Becker's works are a testament to the high regard in which he held him.

In "Metaphysical Time," Kuki draws on the notions of *Para-Existentz* (para-existence) and *Getragenheit* (carriedness) from a 1929 essay of Becker's on the fragility of beauty and the artistic adventure.[17] Despite the coincidence of terminology, Becker's analysis is more than a mere rehash of Heidegger's ideas. In fact, it forms part of his more comprehensive study of what he calls *Dawesen*.[18]

As Kuki reports, Becker advanced the idea of the "para-existential" in opposition to Heidegger's notion of the "existential" to denote the mystical experience of being "carried" along or "floating" along in existence,[19] much the same as Plato and Aristotle imagined the planets as drifting along in the celestial sphere. Heidegger emphasized the "thrownness" of the past and "projection" into the future, but the negative connotations in his idea of the "fallenness" of the present led Becker to reinstate the importance of the present by proposing the term "carriedness" to designate the experience of the "eternal present."[20] What he means by this is that the present is all the time we actually have. In this sense, it is independent of the future and the past, which are subordinate to it.

The eternal present that "carries" us along is the macrocosm that creates the circle of time. Becker refers to time as a "hyper-ontological phenomenon" or simply "hyper-phenomenon," but Kuki goes further to claim that the experience of time is a form of "mystical, metaphysical ecstasy." In a word, he takes Becker's concern with aesthetics and applies it to metaphysics; where Becker understood "para-existence" merely in relation to art, Kuki tried to extend it to include all of reality.

17. "Von der Hinfälligkeit des Schönen und der Abenteuerlichkeit des Künstlers," in Becker 1963.

18. The term is notoriously difficult to translate. Roughly put, it replaces the "being" in *Dasein* with "essence."

19. KSZ 3: 192–4. In this passage, Kuki presents a helpful summary of his idea of the "para-existential."

20. Becker 963, 36–7.

The eternal present is more than a matter of the way human beings experience the world. Kuki argues that is the carrier of the whole of the cosmos. Just as the celestial sphere holds the stars in place and carries the planets around their orbit, there is a power in the cosmos that carries us along as well. For Becker, the microcosm of art that taps into that macrocosm manifests our "fate." Kuki agrees, but shifts the emphasis to the power of the cosmos that turns the cycle of time itself. There is no magical subject in control of fate. The macrocosm writes our fate into the story of its own eternal return.

The ancient Greek cosmologists from which Becker derived his concept of carriedness characterized the primal elements that make up the world as gods. Kuki insists that this is more than an archaic superstition. Elsewhere in his works he singles out any number of features of human life that can be said to point to the same complex of powers that the Greeks intended with their multiplicity of gods. His interest in Japanese mythology and writings like *The Structure of Iki*, "An Essay on Natural Gracefulness," and "A Genealogy of Sensibility"[21] testify to this view. After dismissing the idea of a divine creator in favor of the creative power of the "clever magician" of will, he replaces the creative will with the creative power of the macrocosm. His mention of the Greek gods in this connection is obviously metaphorical, but he goes a step further to clarify that the macrocosm itself is no more than a virtual construct.[22]

Kuki employs the notion of carriedness to characterize primal contingency as *physis*. More than merely describing a matter of concrete fact, carriedness is presented as a metaphysical category. The designation of the macrocosm—the totality of the natural world—as the *physis* which does the carrying reconfirms his point that primal contingency lies at the outer reaches of reason. The natural world comes into being through the self-creative power of the microcosm without the intervention of will, divine or human. The metaphysical foundation of this radical contingency rests on the idea of eternal return, which Kuki will later describe in *The Problem of Contingency* as no more than a hypothesis.

21.『「いき」の構造』KSZ 1: 1–85;「風流に関する一考察」KSZ 4: 60–82;「情緒の系図」KSZ 4: 170–222.

22. KSZ 3: 194.

Beauty and contingency

In his approach to the problem of origins, Kuki proposed two conflicting ideas. On the one hand, he singled out the power of the human will sufficient to create the world; on the other, the absolute passivity of the subject bound to the circle of fate and afloat in the cosmos. The more he developed his idea of primal contingency as an explanation of the origins of reality, the clearer it became that it was inconsistent with an etiology based on the creative power of will. Although the idea and the term "primal contingency" can be traced back to Schelling's *Urzufall*, it was through Kuki's encounter with the thought of Oskar Becker that the active and passive dimensions of contingency were made compatible constituents of the macrocosm and the plurality of microcosms within it.

Kuki's frequent references to fate confirm that his metaphysics is grounded in the human experience of being "carried" along in the macrocosm. The actual series of events that constitute an individual's fate may at first appear to be entirely accidental and the subject's role entirely passive, as if one were floating in space at the whim of the winds of fate. But considered in retrospect, there is meaning to be found in the events, which makes it possible for necessity to appear in an otherwise accidental series of events. In this sense, the subject who is "carried" along by fate can be said to play an active role. This double-sided "carriedness" manifests primal contingency as *psyche*.

Fate and carriedness, however, are not simply a matter of psychology. They have a transcendent ground in the *physis* of the microcosm. Independent of whatever meaning the individual subject discovers in the events of the past, seen as a causal chain, they lead to the idea of a power that carries events in the microcosm through time. Primal contingency is not a first cause in the Aristotelean sense but an ever-present *causa sui* that permeates the birth of things in the world and sustains them in existence.[23] As producer, it is active; as product, it is passive. Or to put it in other words, the active power of the macrocosm excites the passivity of a microcosm and renders it active in its own creation.

Logically, carriedness in the natural world implies a carried and a carrier, but Becker and Kuki approach the question in different ways, largely because

23. KSZ 2: 239.

Becker is fixed on artistic production, whereas Kuki aimed at a more comprehensive metaphysics. To begin with, we need to look more closely at how this double character of primal contingency—as *pshyche* and *physis*—affects their understanding of the relationship between macrocosm and microcosm.

Becker sees fragility as the soul of beauty. The notion of beauty speaks only of what is possible. It becomes actual only when realized in a work of art. Actual beauty appears at the point at which a work of art culminates, the fragile "microcosm" in which the "macrocosm" of the whole is concentrated.[24] Becker explicitly associates fragility with things that are "easily broken,"[25] but in context, the term connotes the subtlety and delicacy with which beauty appears, not the shattering or destruction of beauty in a given work of art. In contrast, Kuki's references to contingency as "fragile" adopt the more literal meaning. Nothing, he says, is more easily broken than contingency. For example, Kuki overlooks the struggles of the poet to control the rhyme in his verses, insisting that the chance encounter of rhyming sounds is responsible for the results. Indeed, he sees the beauty in such fortuitous rhyme as a symbol of the rhythmic beating of the heart.[26]

Kuki presents Becker's position too briefly to permit a proper contrast between their respective views on the relationship between macrocosm and microcosm. To do so, we need to consider Becker's description of the artist as standing midway between the two, such that both pure nature and pure mind are simultaneously at work. It is in the fragile balance between the certainty of being "carried" and the total uncertainty of being a "thrown projection"[27] that ideal beauty comes to expression concretely in a work of art. The two aspects permeate each other and lend the character of "adventuresomeness" to the existence of the artist. Becker refers to the artist as a "metaphysical adventurer" who, in the blink of an eye, transforms the potential of the eternal ideal of beauty into actuality. In sympathy with the present as the moment of eternity in time that reveals the workings of fate in the macrocosm, the artist experiences the fragility of their artistic creation as a microcosm that reflects that macrocosm and concentrates its all-embracing,

24. Becker 1963, 11–13.

25. Becker 1963, 11.

26. KSZ 2: 220.

27. The reference is, of course, to Heidegger's *geworfener Entwurf.*

mystical, metaphysical fate into a specific time and place. Poised between existence and para-existence, the artist combines the two in the actual world as a fragile work of art.[28]

With that in mind, it is clear that Kuki's view of poetry as a microcosm born of sympathy with the macrocosm follows the same line of thought. The beauty expressed in rhyming verse, as the chance encounter of sounds, symbolizes the latent potential for beauty in the macrocosm. As an actualization of the ideal, the rhyme is a manifestation of eternal return in art. Setting aside the question of how well he understood the function of rhyming in Western poetry and its possibilities for Japanese poetry, Kuki's underlying intention is to stress the beauty in the contingency of the rhyme. Unlike Becker, whose aesthetical theory is more comprehensive, we find little in the rest of Kuki's writing on the subject of beauty.

Kuki's fragile metaphysics

Kuki's idea of the beauty of contingency reflects the twofold nature of primal contingency as *psyche* and *physis*. We see a hint of that distinction already in a 1929 essay on "Time in Bergson and Heidegger." He remarks apropos of Leibniz and Husserl, both of whom exerted considerable influence on Kuki's thinking:

> Is it not a matter of some significance that he [Leibniz] regards the monad as a "living mirror of the universe" (*miroir vivant de l'univers*) and discusses the relation between microcosm and macrocosm? When Husserl takes up the relation between cosmological time (*kosmische Zeit*) and phenomenological time (*phänomenologische Zeit*), he thinks in terms of the reflection of the former in the latter, referring to it as a self-representation (*Sichdarstellen*) or self-adumbration (*Sichabschatten*).[29]

In his most famous philosophical work, *The Problem of Contingency*, he relates the macrocosm-microcosm model to the question of origins in clear and unmistakable terms:

28. Becker 1963, 35–40.
29.「時間の問題：ベルグソンとハイデッガー」KSZ 3: 331.

> Each constitutive element in a series, insofar as it is constrained by an absolute origin, reflects the character of that origin; and as long as every part is a part of the whole, the character of the whole is projected in that part.[30]

Put simply, actual existence reflects the metaphysical structure of reality. This means, first, that each part of the universe writ small mirrors the whole of the universe writ large, and secondly, that each moment in time reflects the eternal return of time itself. This complex of the whole and its parts, the ideal and the actual, the spiritual and the physical, the eternal and the now, shares a common origin in primal contingency. Hence Kuki's claim that everything that exists is "beautiful like a poem."[31]

While his argument has its own logic, on the face of it, it is difficult to accept the conclusion that every instant in time and every entity in existence is beautiful without further qualification. Are there not some moments that reflect the macrocosm more beautifully than others? And might there not be moments that do *not* reflect it at all? Does the mystical, metaphysical heart of the cosmos beat in each and every thing at each and every moment? Yes and no.

At the outset we saw Kuki insist that one's metaphysics is a function of one's perspective and existential situation. Accordingly, he looked on his idea of the macrocosm as an ideal construct—that is to say, as para-existential—that depended on his thinking about it and would disappear if he ceased to keep it in mind. This would imply that there could be moments in time and events in the physical world that would fall outside the range of his metaphysics, and therefore that his macrocosm is not "macro" in any objective sense but only as an "image" generated within his subjective perspective and carrying its own mystique. Indeed, we would be forced to conclude that his metaphysics would die with him, just as the unique perspective shaped by his personal existential experience could no longer exist once that experience had come to an end. The solipsism of the "clever magician" who creates the world by sheer force of will seems to have survived, undermining his pursuit of the objective origins of reality.

But in relativizing his metaphysics in connection to his own life and

30.『偶然性の問題』, KSZ 2: 242–3.

31.「岡倉覚三氏の思い出」, KSZ 5: 238.

perspective, Kuki had no intention of denying the *existence* of the objective world. It is no truer to say that everything is "image" than to say that everything is beauty. He meant only to insist that it was *contingent* at its very roots, and that any attempt to explain the world in metaphysical terms was not exempt from that same contingency. As fragile as the world is as it passes from moment to moment in an unending cycle of eternal return, so too is thinking about the world fragile as it passes from perspective to perspective, from mind to mind. In the primal sense, the origins of the world and the origins of our thoughts about the world share in a fragility and contingency that lies at the heart of reality itself.

As we have seen, primal contingency is not only the ontological ground of existence but also the source of its power to act. As *physis*, primal contingency is *causa sui*. It indicates the world "just as it is." The subject takes that world in hand, ponders the latent possibilities in its primal contingency, and reshapes the world through its own performance. In this way, the subject creates a necessary world fitted out with meaning. In examining Kuki's idea of eternal return, we saw a shift in his view of the subject: the "clever magician" who creates reality through an act of will is replaced with the fragile subject "carried" along in the microcosm by the action of the macrocosm. His reading of Becker prompted him to explain the subject of "carriedness" as positioned midway between the microcosm of an individual life and the macrocosm of the life of the whole of reality. From this position, the subject is able to sympathize with the beauty of fate and at the same time create moments of beauty on its own. Accordingly, the function of primal contingency is to provide a rational, metaphysical ground for the eternal return of fate through time. The subject, through its creative activity and in sympathy with the world, incarnates the potential for beauty hidden in the macrocosm.

The fragility of "carriedness" is itself a virtual characterization created in the imagination of the subject. The problem is that we easily become trapped in the *actual* world and forget the unrealized *potential* that imagination opens up to us. This is why constructing the imagery of metaphysics is so important. Precisely because of the fragility of everything in the world, including primal contingency and eternal return, Kuki insists on the need to imagine the world other than it is in order to discover its beauty. The bonds he forges up between existence and para-existence, the physical world of nature and the spiritual world of mind, microcosm and macrocosm, are

all conceived of with that aim in mind. Each encounter in the world is an I-Thou encounter that has the potential to illuminate the way in which everything that exists is "beautiful like a poem." This is how I understand his injunction at the end of *The Problem of Contingency*: "Fais en sorte que les rencontres ne se produisent pas en vain."[32] The resolve to protect this frail and fleeting vision of the world lies at the very heart of Kuki's philosophy. The will to this fragile metaphysics, we might say, is his final answer to the question of origins.

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Abbreviation

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32. Kuki 1935, 196. The original Japanese reads: 遇うて空しく過ぐる勿れ (KSZ 2: 260).